past: the moment when a particular gene in a shared ancestor of my two parents peeled off one copy for one child and another copy to its sibling. That coalescence (unlike the two copies of Victoria's blue eye gene) was a long time ago, and the pair of genes has had a long time to accumulate differences, not least the difference in the eye colours that they mediate.

Now, I said that the coalescence pattern within one individual's genome can be used to reconstruct details of demographic prehistory. Any individual's genome can do this. As it happens, I am one of the people in the world who has had his complete genome sequenced. This was for a television programme called *Sex, Death and the Meaning of Life* which I presented on Channel Four in 2012. Yan Wong, my co-author of *The Ancestor's Tale,* from whom I learned everything I know about coalescence theory and much else besides, seized upon this and did the necessary Li/Durbin style calculations using my genome, and my genome alone, to make inferences about human history. He found a large number of coalescences around 60,000 years ago. This suggests that the breeding population in which my ancestors were embedded was small 60,000 years ago. There were few people around, so the chance of a pair of modern genes coalescing in the same ancestor back at that time was high. There were fewer coalescences 300,000 years ago, suggesting that the effective population size was larger. These figures can be plotted as a graph of effective population size against time. Here's the pattern he found, and it is the same pattern as the originators of the technique would expect to find from any European genome.